


***Report On the Visit to The Association of African Senates Conference***

***Held In***

***Rabat, Kingdom of Morocco***

***8th To 9th April 2026***

# *Theme: The Contribution of Upper Houses of Parliaments to the Consolidation of Democracy and the Preservation of Peace in Africa.*

## 1.0 INTRODUCTION

The Parliament of Zimbabwe participated in the Conference of the Association of African Senates held in Rabat, Kingdom of Morocco from 8th to 9th April 2026. The Zimbabwean delegation was led by the Deputy President of the Senate, Hon. Lt. General (Rtd.) M.R. Nyambuya who was accompanied by Hon. Sen. T. Mohadi, Hon. Sen. S. Munemo, Hon. Sen. R. Bwawanda, Mr. C.K Guvi, Ms. P. P Chabwera, Mrs. M. Kwangware, Mr. P. Muzenda and Mr. A. Kufandirori.

**1.2** The Conference brought together Presidents and representatives of Upper Houses of Parliaments across Africa, alongside inter parliamentary organisations, to deliberate on issues of common interest relating to governance, democracy and peace building on the continent.

The Conference was held under the theme: **"The Contribution of Upper Houses of Parliaments to the Consolidation of Democracy and the Preservation of Peace in Africa."** This engagement provided a strategic platform for benchmarking institutional practices, strengthening parliamentary diplomacy and interrogating the effectiveness of Upper Houses in responding to emerging governance and peace building challenges across Africa.

**The objectives of the Conference included:**

- Strengthening the role of Upper Houses in democratic governance;
- Enhancing inter parliamentary cooperation among African Senates;
- Sharing best practices in legislative oversight, representation and accountability; and
- Deliberating on institutional mechanisms for promoting peace and stability across Africa.

## 2.0 PROCEEDINGS OF THE CONFERENCE

The Conference programme was structured around high-level engagements comprising the Opening Ceremony, a General Debate, a Closed-Door Meeting of Presidents of Senates and a Closing Session.

The Opening Ceremony, officiated by the President of the House of Councillors of the Kingdom of Morocco and the President of the Senate of Côte d'Ivoire, set the tone for the deliberations by emphasising the centrality of strong, credible, and inclusive institutions in sustaining democratic governance and peace. This was followed by statements from Presidents of Senates and

representatives of inter parliamentary bodies, reflecting a shared recognition that democratic resilience in Africa is increasingly dependent on the effectiveness of legislative institutions.

Deliberations during the General Debate, which focused on the Conference theme, underscored the need to reposition Upper Houses from largely procedural review bodies to proactive institutions capable of shaping governance outcomes. Discussions highlighted the importance of strengthening legislative oversight, enhancing inclusivity in representation and expanding the role of Parliaments in conflict prevention and national cohesion.

The Closed-Door Meeting of Presidents of Senates constituted the principal decision-making segment of the Conference and focused on strengthening the institutional framework of the Association of African Senates. Deliberations addressed the launch of the Association's logo and graphic charter and proposals for amendments to the statutes submitted by member states, notably the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Côte d'Ivoire and the Kingdom of Morocco.

The Meeting further demonstrated institutional convergence through the adoption of key amendments to the Association's statutes. These include provisions to broaden membership through the admission, by decision of the Conference, of any Upper House from an African state that is a member of the United Nations, either as a full member or observer. The Conference also resolved to formalise governance arrangements by setting the term of the Association's President at two years and recognising the appointment of the first female President as Honorary President, signalling a progressive commitment to inclusive leadership.

In strengthening the administrative architecture of the Association, it was agreed that the responsibilities of Secretary General will be vested in the Secretary General of the Upper House of the host country. Additionally, the Treasurer will be appointed by the Conference upon nomination by the President, thereby reinforcing internal accountability mechanisms.

The Meeting further endorsed a structured convening framework, comprising an annual meeting hosted by the country holding the rotating presidency and a biennial Conference of Presidents. These measures are set to take immediate effect, reflecting a decisive step towards institutional consolidation and operational clarity. It was also confirmed that the next annual meeting will be held in Rabat, Morocco, in 2027.

The Meeting further culminated in the formal designation of the next President of the Association of African Senates, with Mohamed Ould Errachid assuming the presidency, alongside the determination of themes and venues for upcoming Conferences, thereby setting the strategic direction and continuity of the Association's work

## 3.0 ZIMBABWE'S INTERVENTION

Zimbabwe's intervention articulated a strong institutional perspective grounded in constitutionalism and inclusive governance. The Deputy President of the Senate highlighted the constitutional mandate of Parliament to safeguard democracy, uphold the rule of law and ensure accountability across all arms of the State.

Particular emphasis was placed on the Senate's role as a review chamber that enhances the quality of legislation, as well as its inclusive composition, which integrates elected representatives, traditional leaders, and persons with disabilities. This model was presented as a deliberate mechanism for strengthening national cohesion and ensuring that diverse societal interests are reflected in governance processes.

Furthermore, Zimbabwe underscored the importance of thematic committees in deepening oversight on human rights, peace, and security and advanced the need for Upper Houses to position themselves within early warning and preventive diplomacy frameworks in order to respond more effectively to emerging conflicts.

## 4.0 OBSERVATIONS AND KEY INSIGHTS

The Conference revealed a clear and emerging continental consensus that the relevance of Upper Houses is no longer guaranteed by constitutional design alone, but by their capacity to act as effective, responsive, and influential institutions within governance systems.

A central observation was that many Upper Houses continue to operate below their full potential, constrained by limited technical capacity, weak research support systems and insufficient influence over policy processes. In this regard, institutional strengthening, particularly through enhanced committee systems and evidence based legislative support, remains critical.

Equally significant was the recognition of the expanding role of Upper Houses in peace building. There is a growing expectation that Senates should move beyond traditional legislative functions

to actively contribute to conflict prevention, mediation and national dialogue processes. This reflects a broader shift towards more anticipatory and preventive governance models across the continent.

The importance of inclusivity also emerged strongly, with several countries emphasising the integration of traditional leadership, women, and marginalised groups into parliamentary structures as a means of strengthening legitimacy and social cohesion.

Finally, the Conference reaffirmed the strategic value of inter parliamentary cooperation through the Association of African Senates as a platform for knowledge exchange, peer learning and coordinated responses to shared governance challenges.

## 5.0 RECOMMENDATIONS

In light of the foregoing, it is recommended that the Parliament of Zimbabwe prioritises the strengthening of research and technical support systems within the Senate in order to enhance evidence-based oversight and legislative effectiveness. This should be complemented by efforts to further capacitate thematic committees, particularly in areas relating to governance, peace and security.

There is also need to institutionalise the Senate's role within national peace architecture, including its integration into early warning and preventive diplomacy frameworks. This would enable the Senate to play a more proactive role in anticipating and mitigating emerging conflicts.

Furthermore, the Parliament should deepen its engagement with continental parliamentary platforms, particularly the Association of African Senates, in order to leverage opportunities for institutional learning and strategic collaboration.

Finally, deliberate efforts should be made to enhance the visibility and policy influence of the Senate within national governance processes, ensuring that its contributions translate into measurable and tangible outcomes.

## 6.0 CONCLUSION

The Conference in Rabat provided critical insights into the evolving role of Upper Houses in Africa and underscored the imperative for Senates to transition into more dynamic, responsive and

strategically positioned institutions capable of consolidating democracy and safeguarding peace in increasingly complex governance environments.